



NODUS · COMPLETE VAULT GUIDE

Teaching

Plan courses and assess transparently without outsourcing judgement.

The Teaching vault connects courses, groups, materials and schedules to reusable questions, rubrics, exams and defensible gradebooks. AI may help create teaching content but never evaluates students.

VERSION	Nodus 4.1
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AUDIENCE	Teachers, lecturers and course coordinators.

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Core operation, configuration and the complete vault workflow.

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PART I · FOUNDATION

Core Nodus workflow

Start here if Nodus is new to you. These chapters explain what a vault is, how to move through the application, how sources remain traceable, when a model is optional and how to keep a recoverable copy of the work.

START HERE

1 Welcome to Nodus

Nodus is a local-first desktop workspace for research, teaching and study. Work is organised into focused vaults that share one private engine.

A vault is an independent workspace for one project, course, family or dataset. Changing the vault changes the navigation and assistant context, while the database, indexes and preserved files stay on the computer. Accounts are optional, and model-assisted features run only after a provider or local model has been configured.

WHERE TO FIND IT

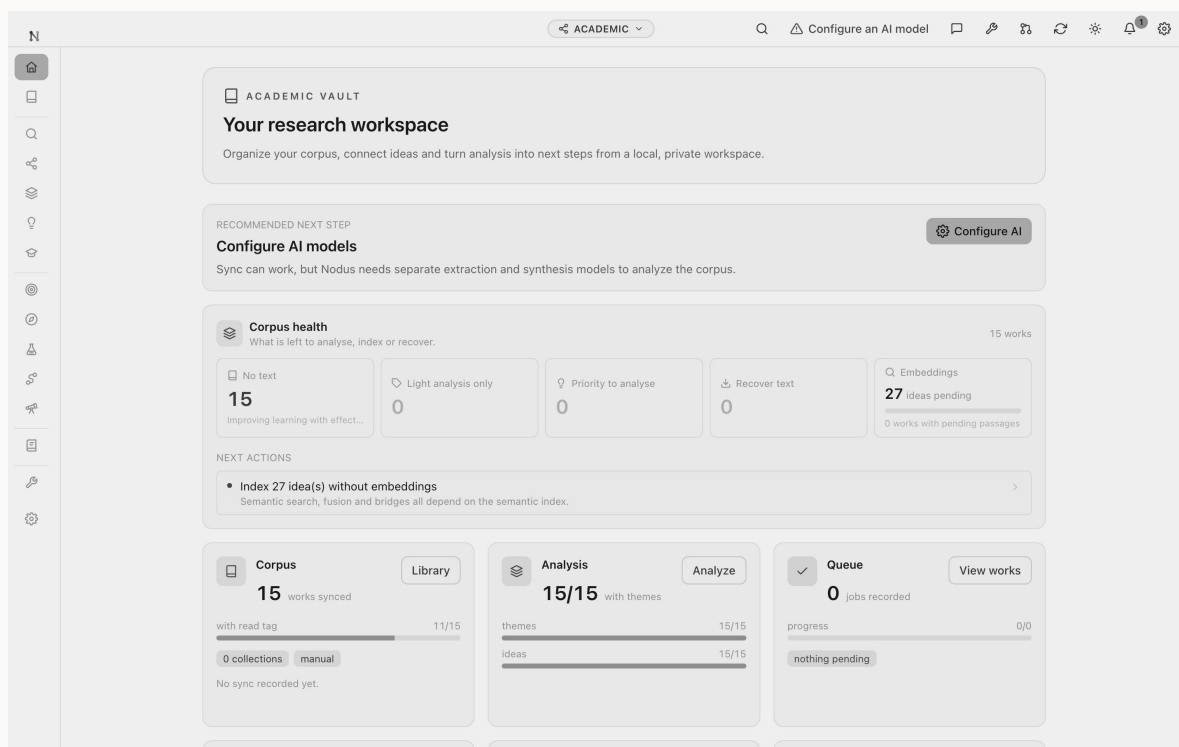
Install Nodus, then open the application

STEP BY STEP

1. Download the package for macOS, Windows or Linux from the Nodus release page and complete the installer.
2. Launch Nodus and complete the short setup: appearance, optional Nodi assistant and the introductory tour.
3. Create the vault that matches the work you are starting, give it a clear name and remain on Home while you learn the layout.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use one vault per coherent project, course, family or dataset.
- Start with a small set of real material that you are allowed to process.



Welcome to Nodus in the Nodus desktop application

START HERE

2 Create and switch vaults

Create independent workspaces and move between them without mixing their context.

The vault switcher is the boundary between projects. Each vault has its own notes, analysis and domain records, while the global Library can link the same source into compatible vaults without duplicating it.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Application header → vault name and icon

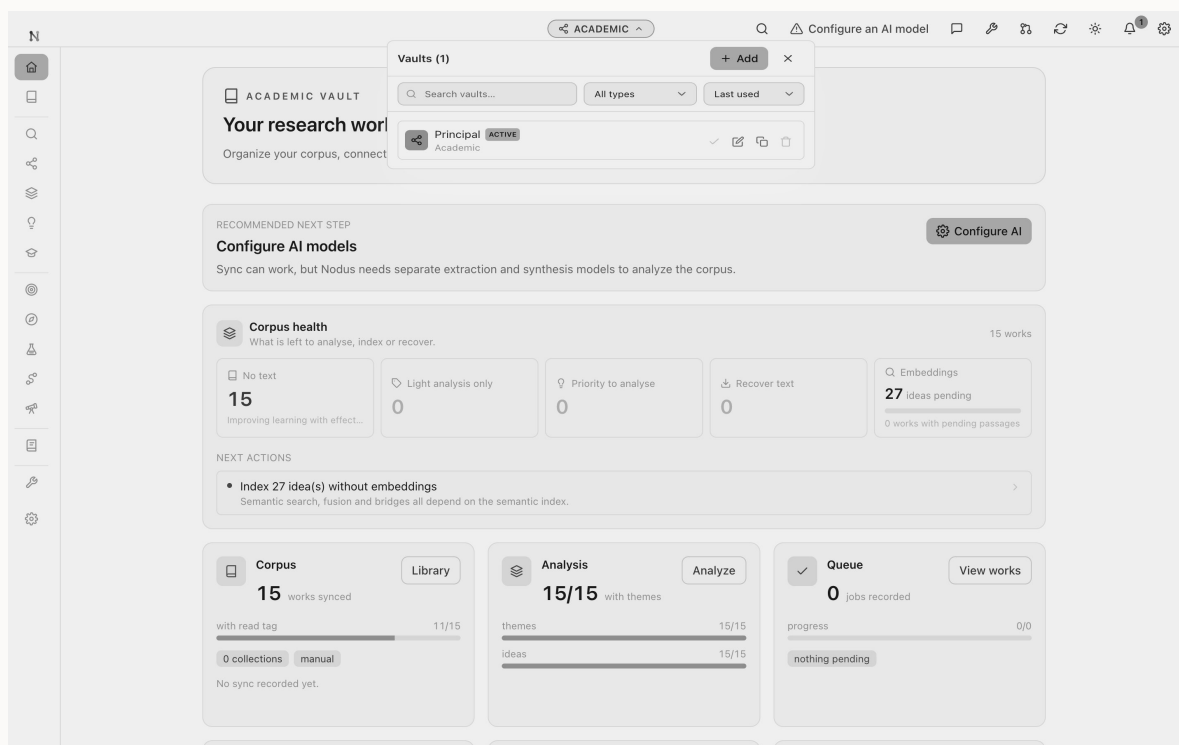
STEP BY STEP

1. Select the current vault name in the centre of the application header, then choose the action to create a vault.
2. Enter a descriptive name, select the correct vault type and read the explanation of the workflow it enables before confirming.
3. Open the same switcher whenever you need another project; choose a vault and wait for its Home view to appear.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use explicit names such as 'MA thesis - memory' or 'Biology 2026'.

- Create a new vault instead of changing the meaning of a mature workspace.



Create and switch vaults in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

3 Navigation and global search

The sidebar exposes the workflow for the active vault; search retrieves material across the relevant local index.

The narrow left sidebar contains the active vault's tools. Hover an icon to read its label. The magnifying-glass button opens search, while the vault button in the header changes workspace. Keyword search works immediately; semantic retrieval also requires an embedding model.

WHERE TO FIND IT

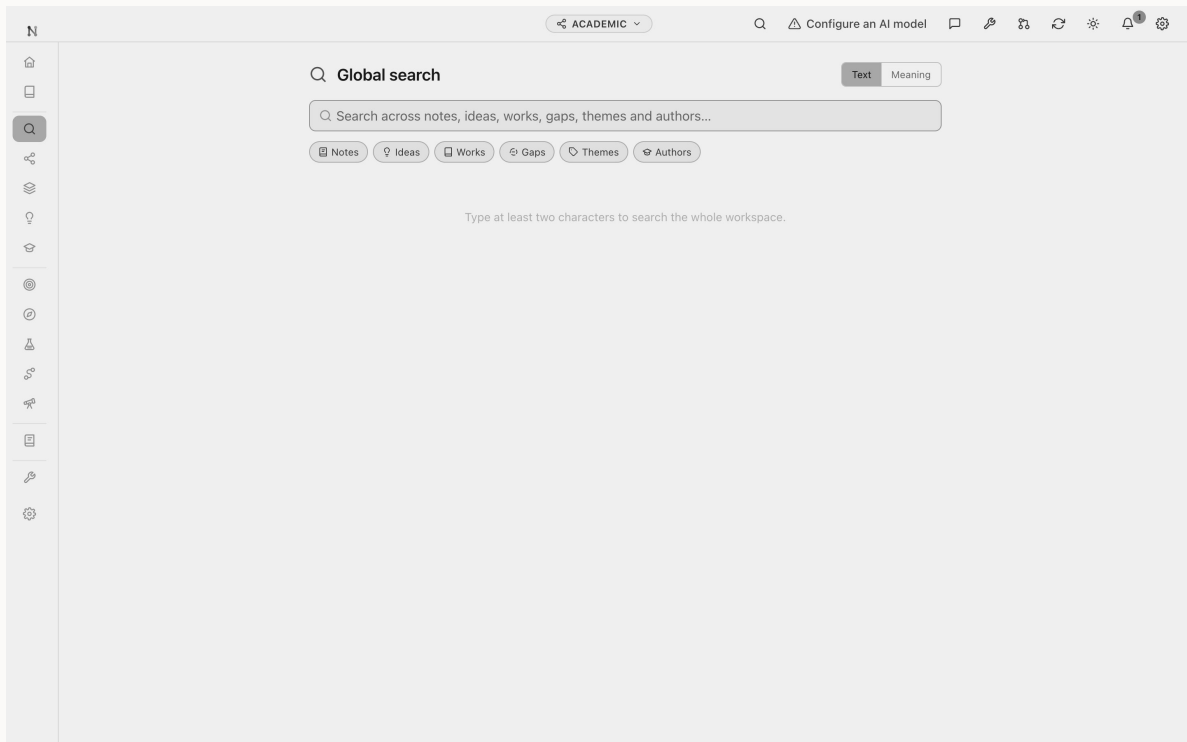
Left sidebar → magnifying-glass icon

STEP BY STEP

1. Move the pointer over sidebar icons until the label for the section you need appears, then select it; the active icon receives the vault colour.
2. Open Search and enter a title, name, quotation or concept of at least two meaningful characters.
3. Apply a type or scope filter when available, open a result and follow its source link to the original document, record, person or note.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Search for concepts as well as exact titles.
- Rebuild an index from Settings if recently imported content does not appear.



Navigation and global search in the Nodus desktop application

ESSENTIALS

4 Library, sources and reader

Keep preserved originals beside clean reading copies, citations, highlights and extracted evidence.

The cross-vault Library can mirror Zotero, import RIS, BibTeX and CSL JSON, or accept files directly. Nodus preserves the original attachment and creates searchable derivatives. Compatible sources can be linked to several vaults without copying the original.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Library, sources and reader

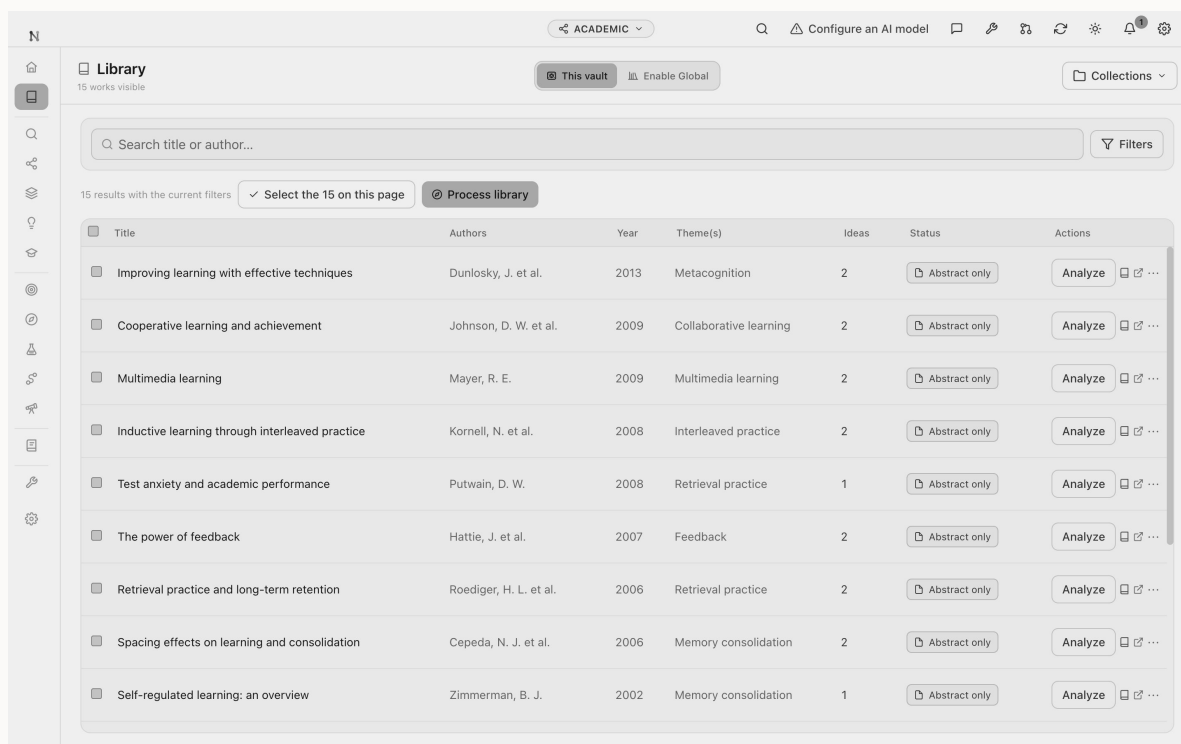
STEP BY STEP

1. Open Library and add a local file, import bibliographic data or connect Zotero.
2. Place the item in a collection and add useful tags; wait for extraction and indexing to finish.

3. Open the item, choose the clean reading copy or preserved original, then highlight passages and link the item into the active vault.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep the preserved original for page-accurate verification.
- Treat automatically extracted text and metadata as a first pass that may need correction.



Library, sources and reader in the Nodus desktop application

CONFIGURATION

5 AI providers and task models

Bring your own cloud key or use compatible local models, with a different model for each task.

Nodus can be used without a model for deterministic organisation and editing. Features that generate, explain or synthesise text need a configured provider or compatible local endpoint. Provider keys are stored in the operating-system keychain, and task models let extraction, chat and reports use different choices.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Left sidebar → Settings → AI and providers

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings and find the AI provider section. Choose a cloud provider or enter the address of a compatible local endpoint.
2. Enter the required credential, use the connection test and resolve any error before continuing.
3. Assign a model to each available task, save the settings and test it on a small, non-sensitive source.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A local model improves privacy but may require more memory and time.
- Review every generated claim against its linked evidence.

CONFIGURATION

6 Privacy, backups and recovery

Protect local work with a verified backup and understand exactly when network services are used.

Vault databases, indexes and library files are local by default. Backups can include all vaults and the shared Library. Nodus reports backup health and creates protected recovery copies before major migrations.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Nodus → Privacy, backups and recovery

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, choose a backup destination and enable automatic backups.
2. Run a manual backup, then use verification to confirm that its manifest and files are readable.
3. Review the privacy notice for each optional online feature before sending content.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Store backups on a different physical device or a trusted encrypted location.
- Do not treat sync as a backup; keep versioned recovery copies.

CONFIGURATION

7 Toolkit and integrations

Convert, protect, translate, OCR and present documents, or connect Zotero, Word, MCP clients and Nodus Server.

Toolkit contains file utilities shared by every vault. Integrations are optional: Zotero supplies bibliographic material, Word can use selected Nodus context, MCP exposes approved local tools, and Nodus Server

publishes a selected copy rather than the source vault.

WHERE TO FIND IT

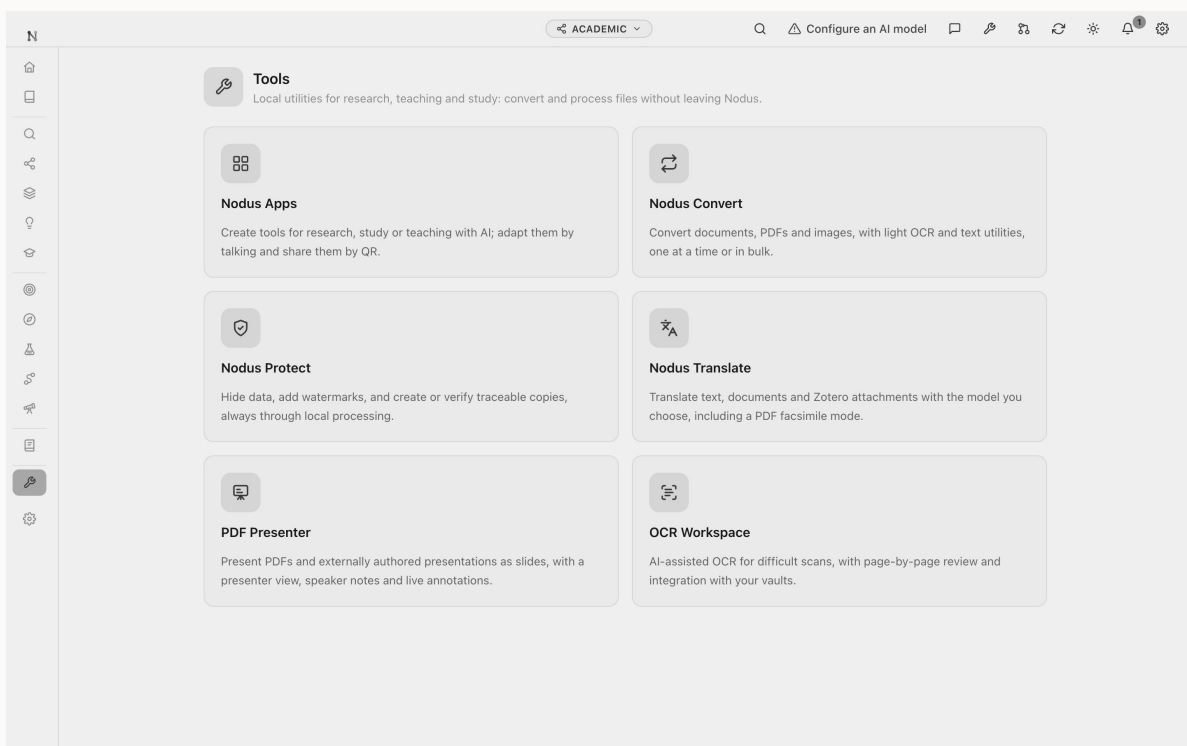
Left sidebar → wrench icon → Toolkit

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Toolkit and choose Convert, Protect, Translate, OCR Workspace or PDF Presenter.
2. Select a file from disk or a compatible vault source, then review every output option and destination.
3. For an integration, enable only the connector you need and test it with a non-sensitive file before using project material.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Permanent redaction in Protect is local and irreversible in the exported copy.
- Published server spaces should contain only material intended for their readers.

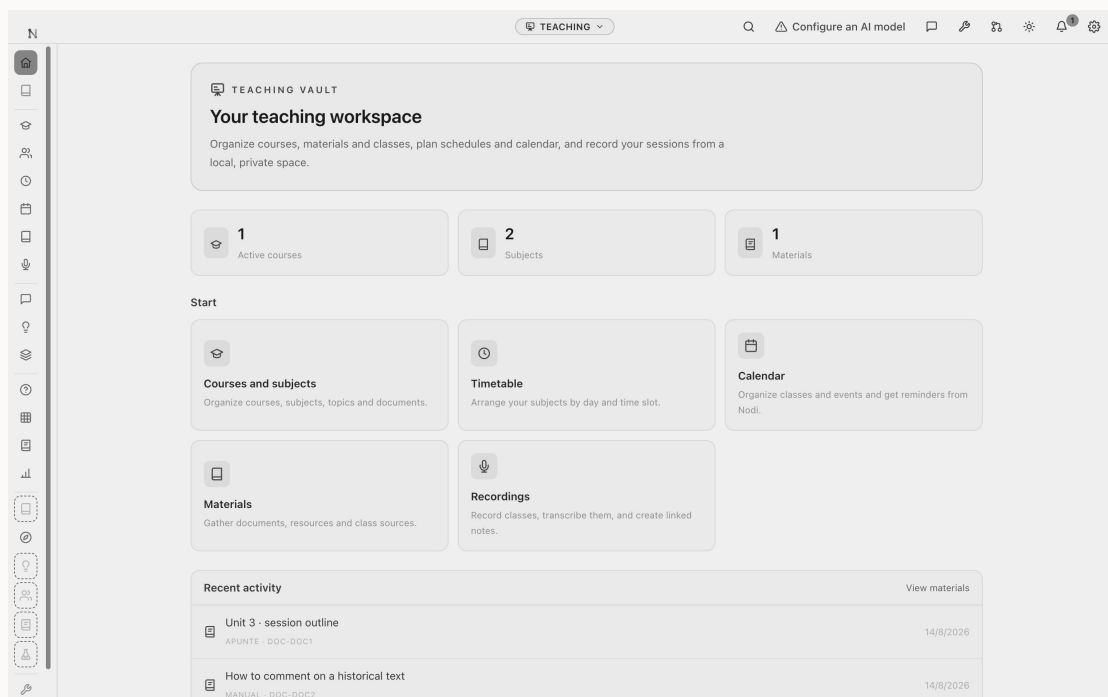


Toolkit and integrations in the Nodus desktop application

PART II · VAULT GUIDE

Complete Teaching workflow

The Teaching vault connects courses, groups, materials and schedules to reusable questions, rubrics, exams and defensible gradebooks. AI may help create teaching content but never evaluates students.



Teaching vault home in the Nodus desktop application

ORIENTATION

1 Home and academic-year overview

Resume the current course and monitor groups, rubrics, exams and gradebooks.

Home provides shortcuts and recent activity while keeping assessment objects attached to their subject and academic year.

WHERE TO FIND IT

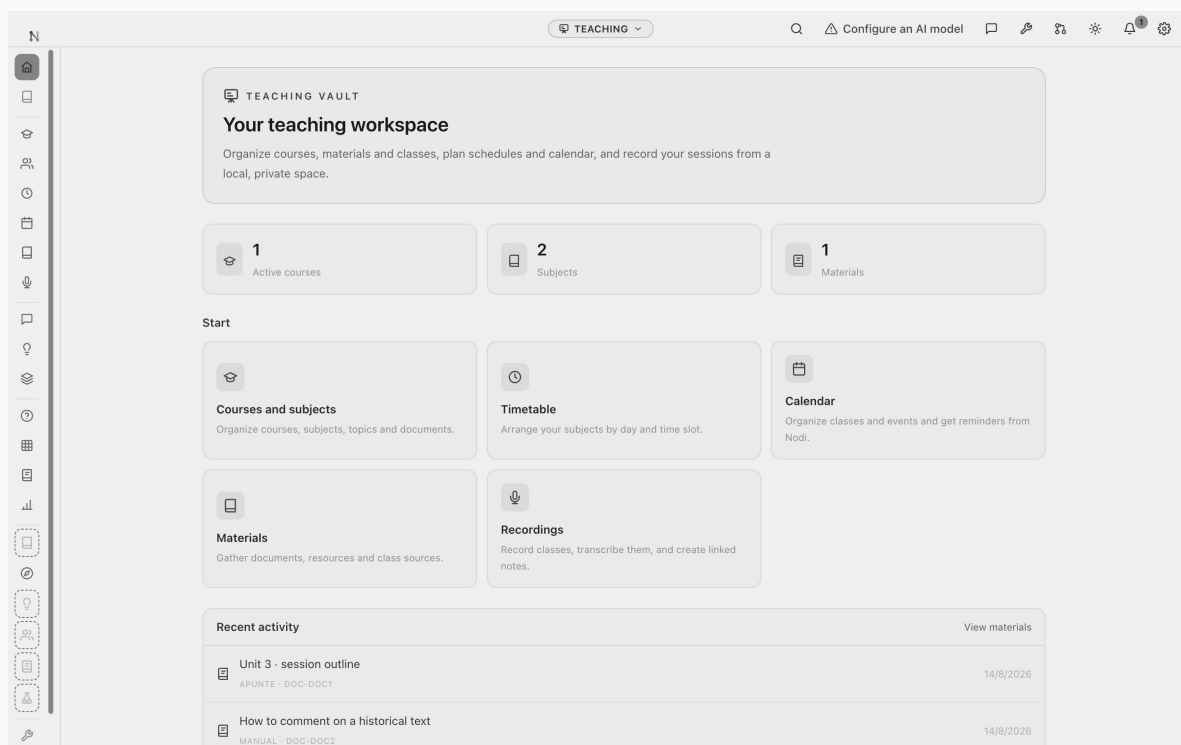
Teaching vault → Home and academic-year overview

STEP BY STEP

1. Confirm the active academic year and course.
2. Review group, rubric, exam and gradebook totals.
3. Open the most relevant recent item or start destination.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Archive completed years rather than reusing their assessment objects silently.



Home and academic-year overview in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

2 Courses and subjects

Define the academic-year structure that materials and assessment will reference.

Subjects carry consistent names, colours and schedules. A course is the organisational parent for planning and reporting.

WHERE TO FIND IT

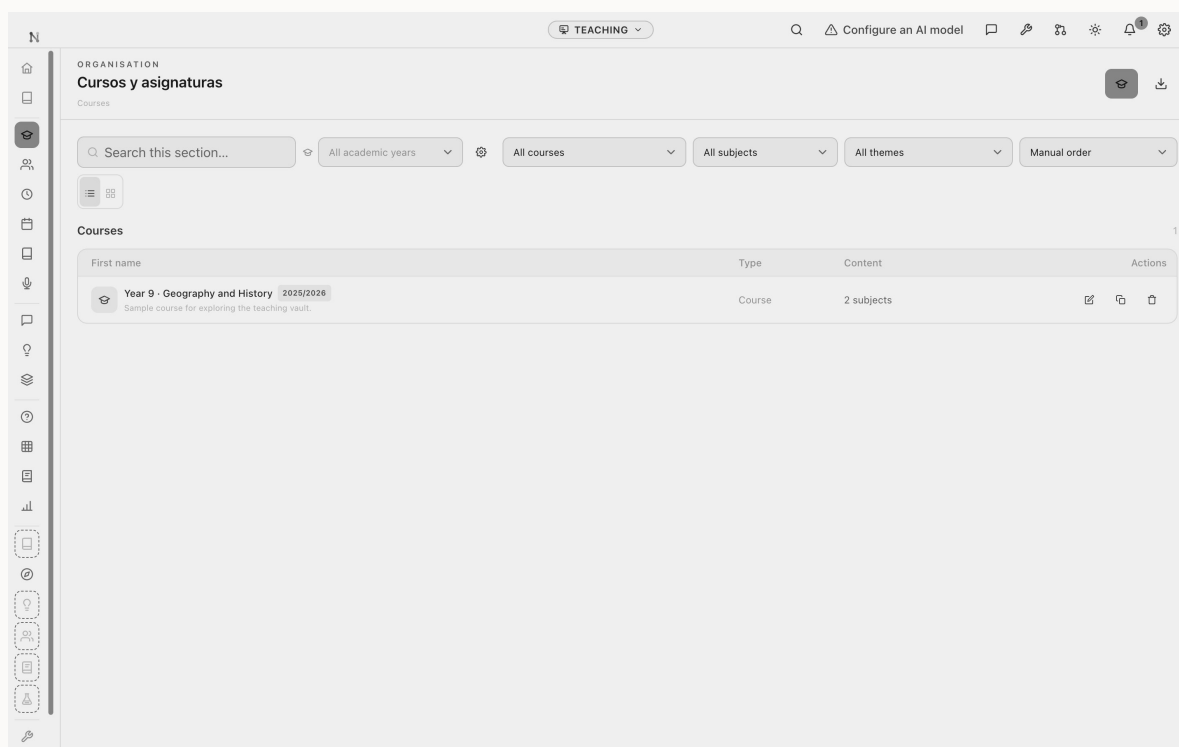
Teaching vault → Courses and subjects

STEP BY STEP

1. Create the academic year and course.
2. Add subjects with clear codes, names, colours and teaching load.
3. Review that groups, materials and assessment objects point to the correct subject.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep historical subjects unchanged after grades are published.



Courses and subjects in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

3 Groups and private rosters

Keep class lists attached to the right subject and year.

Roster data remains local and is excluded from AI workflows. Group views support organisation, not automated profiling.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Groups and private rosters

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a group and choose its subject and academic year.
2. Add students manually or import the approved roster format.
3. Review identifiers and duplicates, then restrict exports to the minimum necessary data.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Never paste names, grades or student answers into an AI prompt.

ORGANISATION

4 Timetable

Arrange recurring teaching slots with subject identity and location.

Timetable represents the weekly pattern; Calendar carries individual dates, deadlines and exceptions.

WHERE TO FIND IT

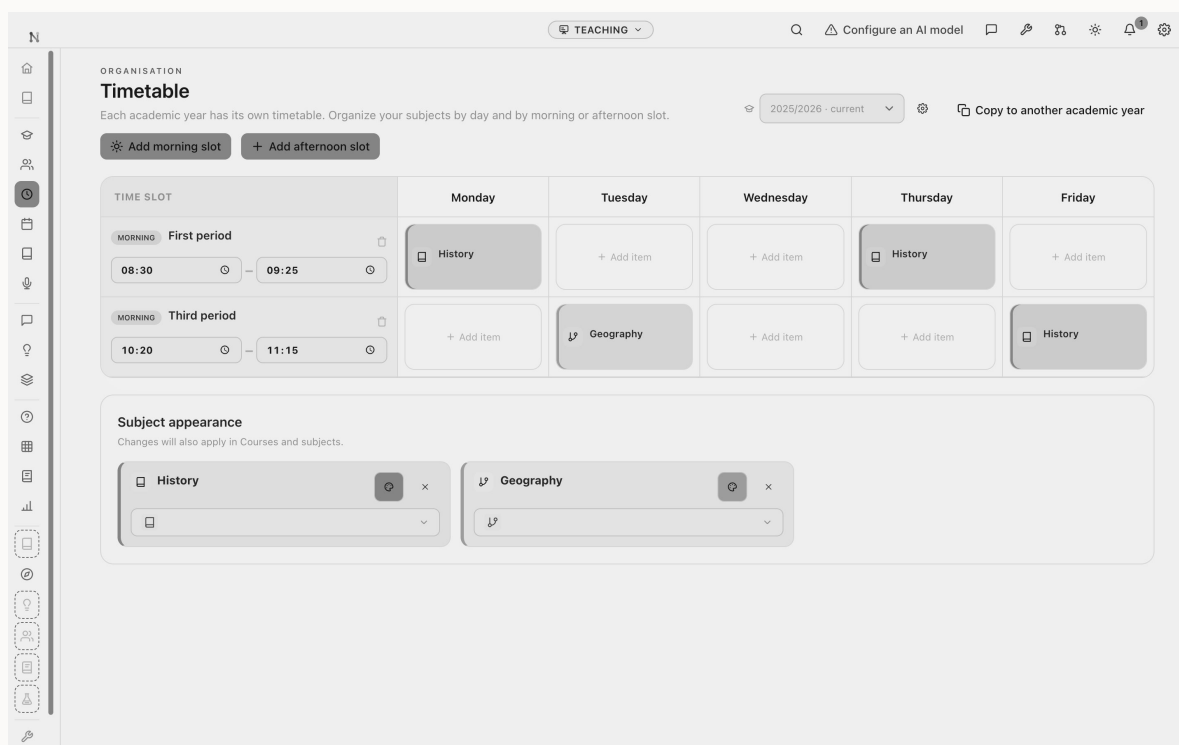
Teaching vault → Timetable

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose the active year and week layout.
2. Add class blocks with subject, group, time and room.
3. Check collisions and add one-off changes to Calendar.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Record the time zone for remote or cross-campus teaching.



Timetable in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

5 Calendar

Plan sessions, deadlines, exams and reminders.

Dated events can link back to courses, subjects and assessment objects, keeping preparation and delivery together.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Calendar

STEP BY STEP

1. Create an event with type, date and related subject.
2. Add a local reminder and a link to the relevant material or exam.
3. Review month and agenda views for workload conflicts.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Add moderation and feedback deadlines, not only student-facing dates.

ORGANISATION

6 Teaching materials

Organise source files and classroom resources by subject and unit.

Materials can support question or rubric drafting, but generated content must be reviewed by the teacher.

WHERE TO FIND IT

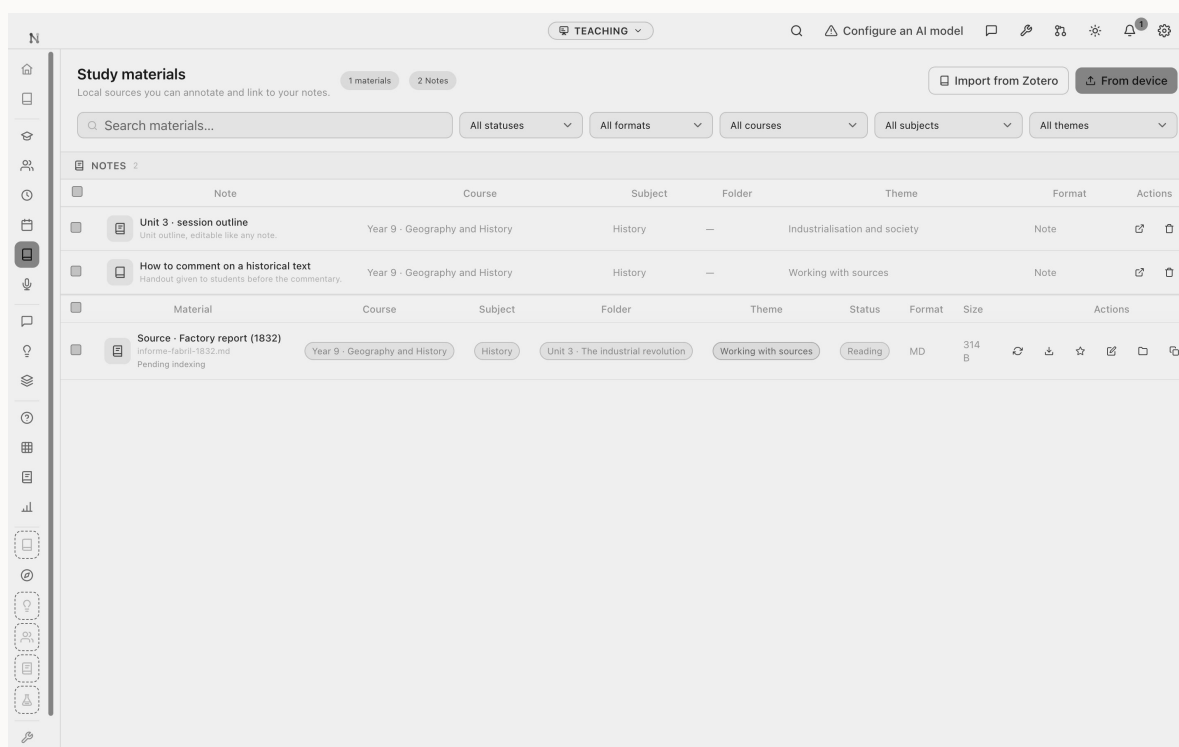
Teaching vault → Teaching materials

STEP BY STEP

1. Import or create a material and assign subject, topic and audience.
2. Review extraction and preserve the original file.
3. Link the material to sessions or use a selected scope when drafting questions.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Check licensing before distributing third-party material.



Teaching materials in the Nodus desktop application

ORGANISATION

7 Recordings

Keep permitted class recordings and transcripts attached to the course.

Local transcription reduces unnecessary disclosure. Recording and retention must follow institutional policy and participant consent.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Recordings

STEP BY STEP

1. Confirm consent and choose the correct subject before recording or import.
2. Transcribe locally and review errors.
3. Link useful segments to teaching notes or materials, then apply the retention policy.

GOOD PRACTICE

- A pedagogical use case does not override recording consent.

CREATE

8 Teaching chat

Discuss a course topic with selected teaching materials as the evidence base.

Teaching chat can explain, compare and draft non-personal learning content from the chosen subject. It must not receive rosters, grades, submissions or identifiable student information.

WHERE TO FIND IT

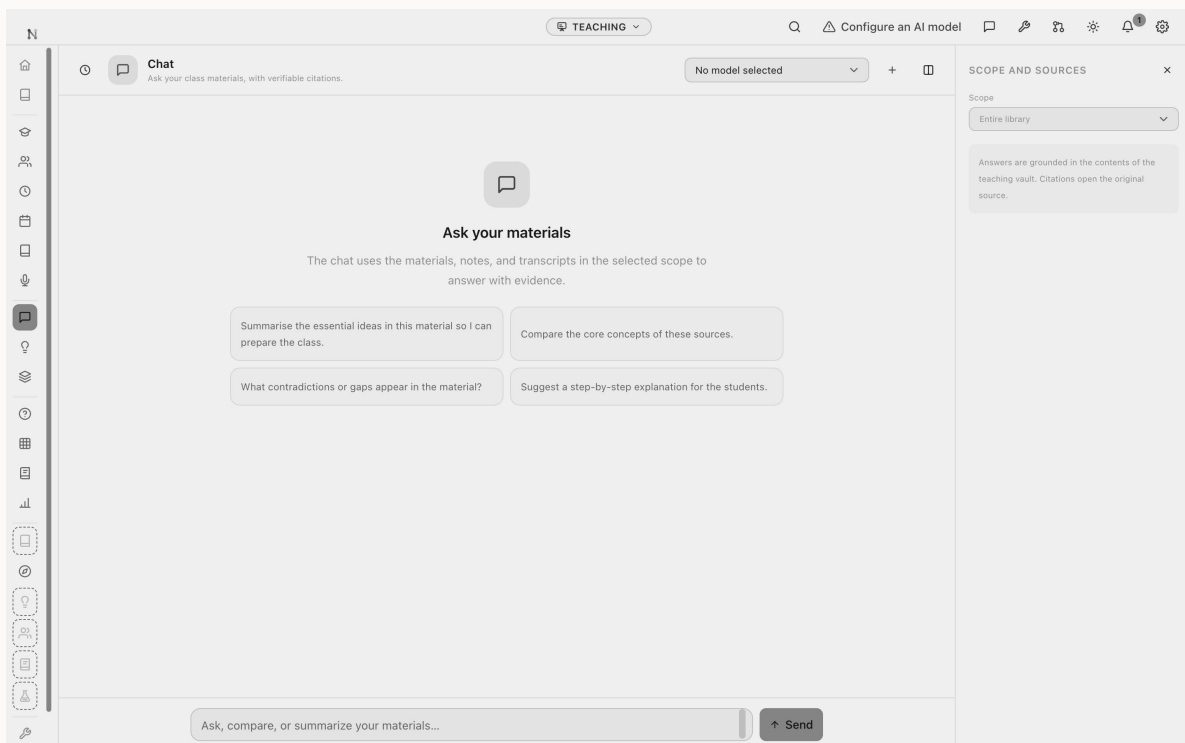
Teaching vault → Teaching chat

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose the subject and inspect which materials are included in the conversation scope.
2. Ask for a bounded explanation, outline or activity and state the intended level.
3. Open the cited material, correct unsupported statements and move only reviewed content into a teaching resource.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Start a new conversation when the subject or intended audience changes.



Teaching chat in the Nodus desktop application

CREATE

9 Teaching ideas

Review concepts extracted from course materials before reusing them in activities or assessment.

Ideas keep short concepts and relationships attached to their supporting passage. They provide a reusable layer between raw materials and teacher-reviewed outputs.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Teaching ideas

STEP BY STEP

1. Filter ideas by subject or source and open one relevant concept.
2. Read the supporting passage and correct an over-broad label or relationship.
3. Use reviewed ideas as inputs for an explanation, question or unit activity.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep one central concept per idea so later reuse stays precise.

CREATE

10 Teaching graph

Explore course concepts and their typed relationships as a visual map.

The graph helps reveal prerequisites, contrasts and isolated concepts. It represents the materials in the vault and does not replace a curriculum standard or teacher judgement.

WHERE TO FIND IT

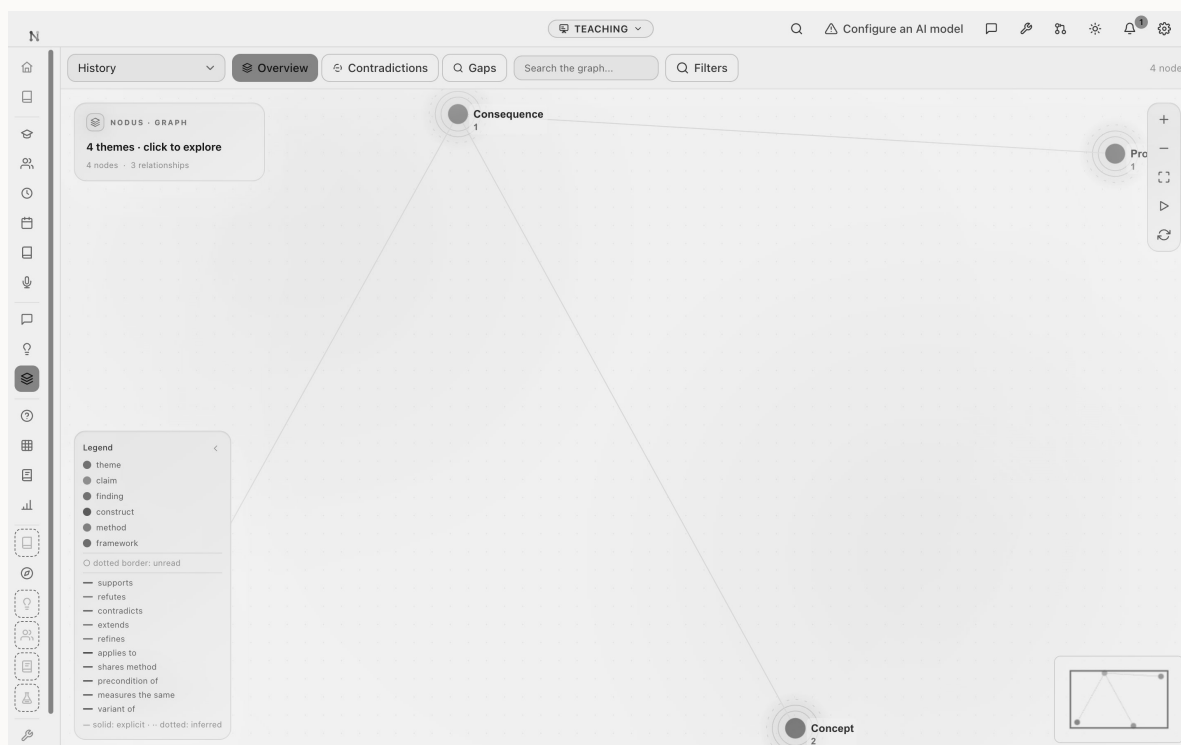
Teaching vault → Teaching graph

STEP BY STEP

1. Choose a subject and an overview or topic focus.
2. Select a node and inspect its immediate relationships and evidence.
3. Use gaps or weak connections to revise materials, an explanation or a unit sequence.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use the graph to ask better planning questions, not as an automatic curriculum.



Teaching graph in the Nodus desktop application

ASSESSMENT

11 Question bank

Create reusable questions by subject, topic, type and difficulty.

Questions can be drafted manually or from selected teaching material. AI output remains unapproved content and is never used to evaluate a student.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Question bank

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a question or generate a draft from an explicit material scope.
2. Review wording, expected answer, marking guidance, difficulty and accessibility.
3. Approve and tag the question before adding it to an exam.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Maintain parallel items and review for cultural or linguistic bias.

ASSESSMENT

12 Rubrics

Define weighted criteria and achievement levels before marking.

A rubric separates criteria, performance descriptors and weights. Publishing or locking a version protects the assessment basis from silent changes.

WHERE TO FIND IT

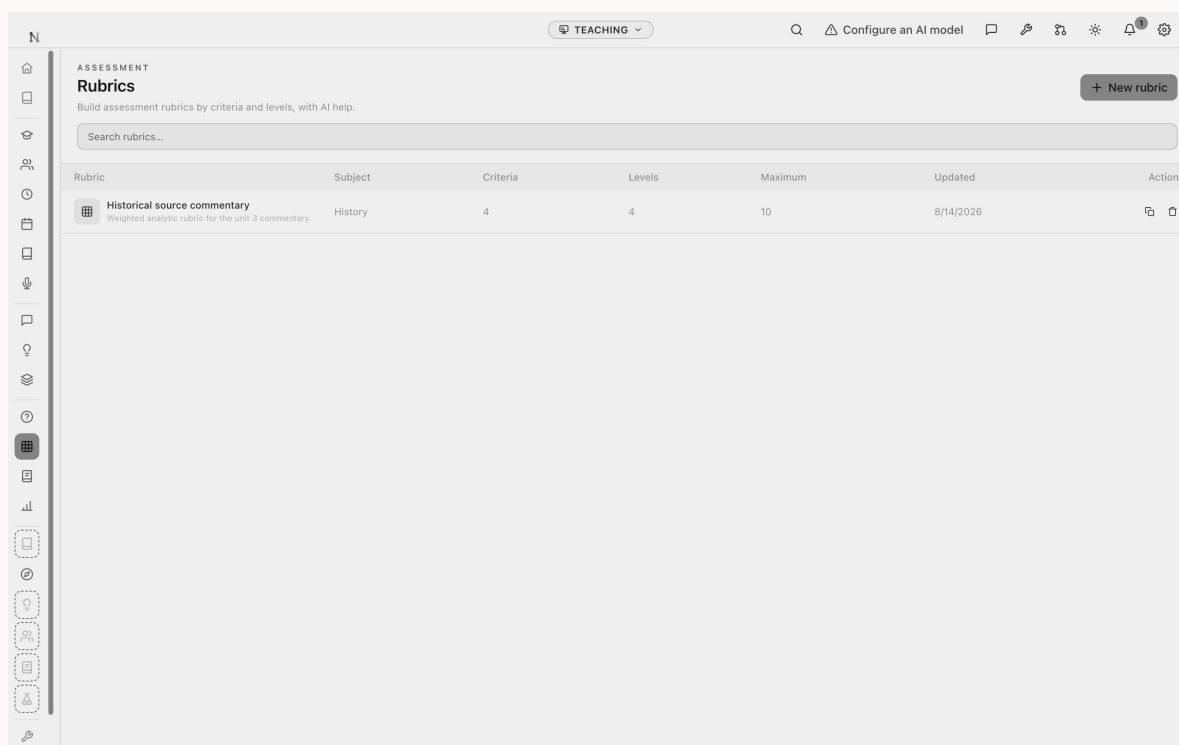
Teaching vault → Rubrics

STEP BY STEP

1. Create a rubric for a subject and assessment task.
2. Add distinct criteria, weights and observable descriptors at each level.
3. Validate the total, pilot on sample work and publish the approved version.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Describe observable performance, not personality or presumed effort.



Rubrics in the Nodus desktop application

ASSESSMENT

13 Exam builder and print export

Compose an exam from approved questions with a live printable preview.

The builder manages sections, points, instructions and answer keys. Export creates a professional paper while the teacher controls the final content.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Exam builder and print export

STEP BY STEP

1. Create an exam with subject, duration, instructions and total points.
2. Add approved questions, organise sections and inspect pagination in the preview.
3. Generate the student paper and solution copy, then proofread both before printing.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Check that points, time and cognitive demand align with the published plan.

ASSESSMENT

14 Gradebooks and assessment plans

Apply transparent weighting rules without turning every blank into zero.

A gradebook derives its rules from a published assessment plan and distinguishes missing, excused and not-yet-entered values. AI never grades or profiles students.

WHERE TO FIND IT

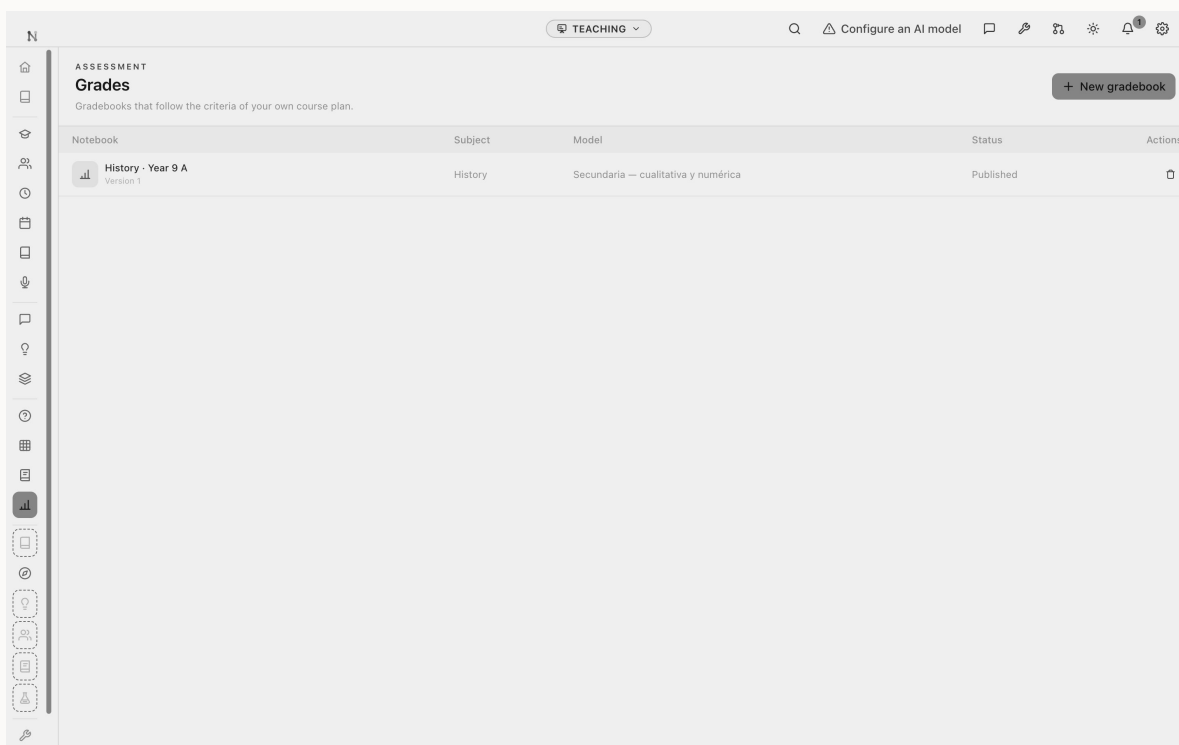
Teaching vault → Gradebooks and assessment plans

STEP BY STEP

1. Create or select the approved assessment plan and verify weights.
2. Create the gradebook for the correct group and enter or import marks.
3. Review missing-value semantics, calculations and outliers before publishing or exporting.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Keep an audit trail for manual overrides and moderation decisions.



Gradebooks and assessment plans in the Nodus desktop application

CREATE

15 Units and learning design

Plan outcomes, units and aligned activities in the course structure.

Units connect intended learning, ordered teaching material and assessment preparation. They are most useful when each unit has a clear boundary and an observable outcome.

WHERE TO FIND IT

Teaching vault → Units and learning design

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Units and create a unit under the correct course or subject.
2. Add the intended outcomes, sequence and links to the materials that support each stage.
3. Connect appropriate questions, rubrics or exams, then review the alignment before teaching starts.

GOOD PRACTICE

- Use observable learning outcomes that can be checked without profiling a student.

CONFIGURE

16 Privacy and responsible AI

Use AI for teaching content only; keep rosters, marks and student answers out of models.

Nodus enforces a domain boundary around student data. Deterministic calculations and professional judgement remain local; optional models may draft non-personal teaching material.

WHERE TO FIND IT

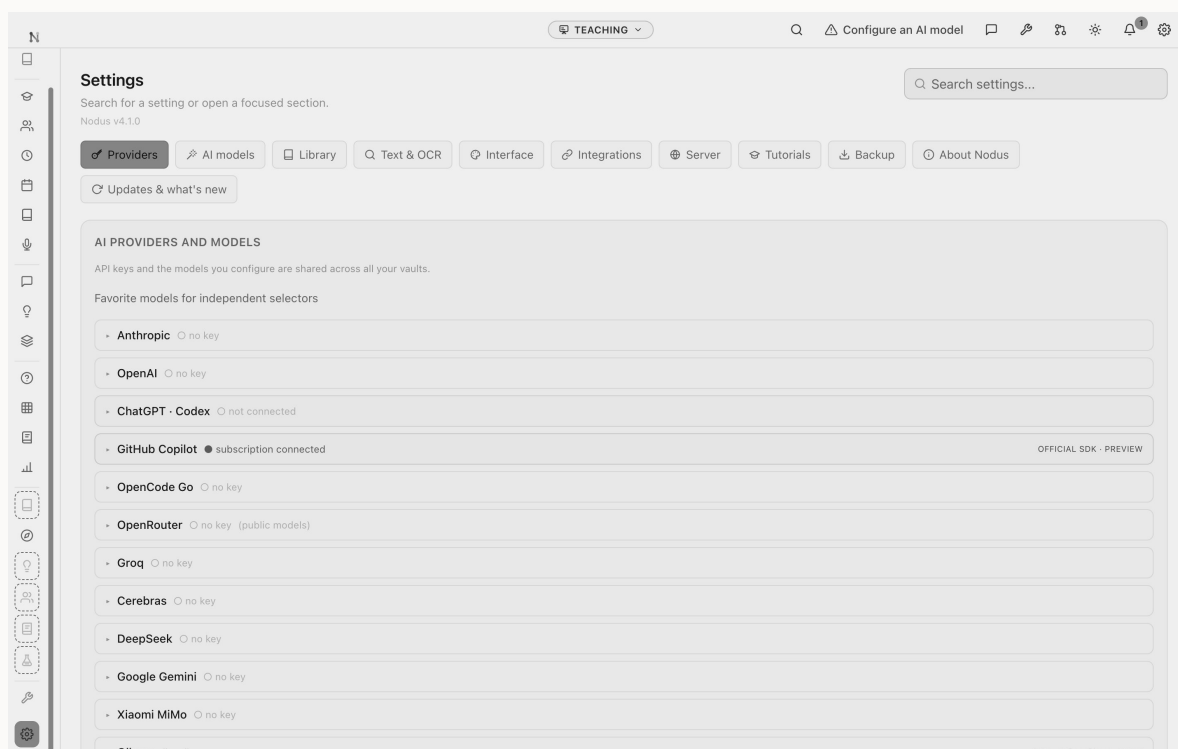
Teaching vault → Privacy and responsible AI

STEP BY STEP

1. Open Settings, configure only the providers needed for content preparation and read the teaching AI boundary.
2. Use only non-student course material for optional generation; never include names, marks, submissions or behavioural observations.
3. Verify backups, local access controls and export destinations before adding a live roster.

GOOD PRACTICE

- If a task evaluates, predicts or profiles a student, do not send it to AI.



Privacy and responsible AI in the Nodus desktop application

REFERENCE

Completion checklist

- The vault scope and name match the project.
- Sources or records have preserved originals and reviewed metadata.
- Generated interpretations have been checked against their evidence.
- Optional providers and integrations use only the intended data.
- Exports have been proofread in their final format.
- A recent backup has been created and verified.

This manual documents the desktop workflow represented in Nodus 4.1. Interface details may evolve between releases; the in-app privacy notice and release notes govern the exact behaviour of the installed version.